embroidered reality by highlighting the search for Sita set into motion just then. Even if it meant taking some liberty with details, her effort at defusing a conflict between the brothers and the *vanaras* (monkeys) was successful. If Tara stands out, it is also because she is an exception to the self-absorption that characterizes her kith and kin.

The three cases may be different from each other in objectives and approaches. But what brings them together is a shared understanding of the larger task that confronts them. They have to grasp the enormity of the threat and actively contribute to the search for solutions. There is both a sensitivity required in respect of the larger environment as well as an awareness of their own predicament. Strategic choices have to be advanced but in a tactically astute manner. Honouring of commitments and upholding of principles are essential, but even these need to be optimized. The complex dynamic between the landscape and the game plan is always a perennial issue in diplomacy. Getting them both right is the prerequisite for success.

TOWARDS AN UNCERTAIN, INSECURE FUTURE

Pondering over the complexities of our own times, we might want to start by reflecting on how a pandemic that first engulfed a distant Chinese city then went on to completely take over our lives for more than two years. Or how and why an ongoing conflict in Europe, an entire continent away, is now affecting our daily life and its costs. And for that matter, the implications that climate events are having on the many processes that we take for granted. Or it could be a different kind of trauma, were any of us to be caught up in an act of terrorism or distantly inspired violence. In some cases, as we saw with students trapped in Ukraine or travellers stranded during Covid, stresses might happen when we are out of our country. But in others, be it Covid, conflict, terrorism or natural disasters, such developments can come right to our doorstep, sometimes even inside our homes. In the age of globalization, there is no escape from the world.

That does not mean that we need to be apprehensive about global developments or defensive in our approach. The flipside of the very interdependence is that the same world is also full of possibilities. If we brought back 7 million plus Indians during Covid through the Vande Bharat Mission, it reminds us that the India of today utilizes the global workplace extensively. It is equally due to the fact that our talents and skills are now an intrinsic element of global innovation, manufacturing and services. This is also reflective of how many Indians travel for personal or professional